

From a Railway Carriage



Have you ever travelled by train or by bus, and looked out of the window? What did you see? Here is a poem that describes what the poet sees from the window of a railway carriage.

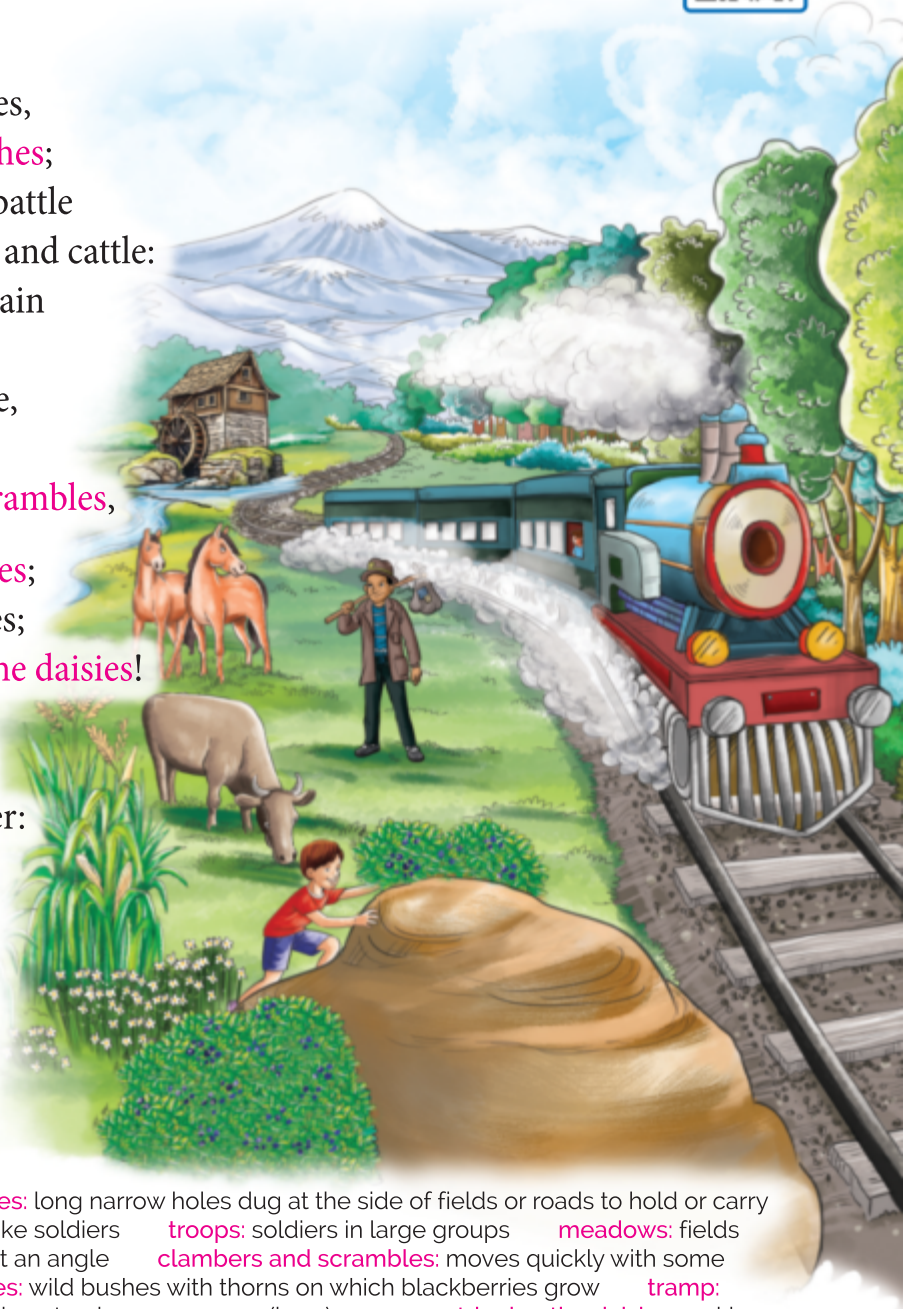
Read the poem aloud—loudly! Decide where you want to pick up the tempo and read faster and still faster. Notice how the rhythm of the lines feels like the rhythm of a train on the tracks!



Faster than fairies, faster than witches,
Bridges and houses, **hedges** and **ditches**;
And **charging along** like **troops** in a battle
All through the **meadows** the horses and cattle:
All of the sights of the hill and the plain
Fly as thick as **driving** rain;
And ever again, in the wink of an eye,
Painted stations whistle by.
Here is a child who **clambers and scrambles**,

All by himself and gathering **brambles**;
Here is a **tramp** who stands and gazes;
And here is the **green** for **stringing the daisies**!
Here is a cart runaway in the road
Lumping along with man and load;
And here is a mill, and there is a river:
Each a **glimpse** and gone for ever!

R.L. Stevenson



hedges: a row of bushes or small trees **ditches**: long narrow holes dug at the side of fields or roads to hold or carry water **charging along**: (here) rushing ahead like soldiers **troops**: soldiers in large groups **meadows**: fields covered in grass **driving**: falling very fast or at an angle **clambers and scrambles**: moves quickly with some difficulty, using both hands and feet **brambles**: wild bushes with thorns on which blackberries grow **tramp**: a person with no home or job who travels from place to place **green**: (here) grass **stringing the daisies**: making a garland by linking daisies together **lumping**: struggling to move with the weight it is carrying **glimpse**: a quick, unclear look at something/somebody

R.L. Stevenson (1850–1894) was born in Edinburgh, Scotland. A versatile writer, he wrote several poems, short stories, novels and essays. He is best known for his novels *Treasure Island*, *Kidnapped* and *Strange Case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde*. The poem given here is from his book titled *A Child's Garden of Verses* published in 1885.



Make connections

Answer the following questions based on the poem.

In this section, we will:

- recognize relevant details to answer questions based on the poem.
- identify and interpret the central ideas of a poem. (C-2.1, C-2.2)

1. Tick (✓) the correct sequence in which these things are listed in the poem.

- stations, a child, a mill, a river, a cart
- a child, stations, a river, a mill, a cart
- stations, a child, a cart, a mill, a river
- a cart, stations, a child, a mill, a river



2. Read these lines and answer the questions that follow.

a. *All of the sights of the hill and the plain*

Fly as thick as driving rain;

- List five sights that the poet has mentioned in the poem.
- Why did the poet compare the things he saw to 'driving rain'?
- Briefly explain the poetic device used in these lines to bring about a comparison.

b. *And ever again, in the wink of an eye,*

Painted stations whistle by.

- In your own words, give the meaning of 'in the wink of an eye'.
- What is actually whistling by? What is not moving?
- After these lines, the poet described three people whom he saw. Who were they?

3. List all the words in the poem that describe movement.

4. To show the speed of the train, the poet said that the things he saw were speeding by. Were these things really speeding? What do you think of this idea?

5. What does 'each a glimpse and gone for ever' mean? How do you think the poet felt as he wrote this line?



Appreciation



Alliterations

Read the given sentence aloud.

- Faster than fairies, faster than witches,

Do you hear the /f/ sound being repeated in this line? It is called **alliteration**.

When words that start with the same sound are used close together in a sentence, it is called **alliteration**.



Let's look at another sentence.

- The busy bees buzzed around the big brown bear.

In this sentence, the /b/ sound is being repeated over and over again to form an alliteration.

1. Here are a few more examples of alliteration for you to read aloud.



- On a warm but windy day, Wendy and Wally walked down the winding street.
- Hungry Henry hurried home and ate a huge slice of honeydew melon.
- Go and gather in groups on the freshly grown green grass.
- The proud peacock pushed the pretty purple pillow off the pile of pineapples.

2. Creating alliterations is great fun. Try making up some of your own using the prompts given below.

- Terence the Tiger takes _____.
- Seven snakes _____.
- Ryan runs and _____.
- The pretty pink _____.
- The large lazy _____.
- The hungry hippo _____.
- The chattering chimpanzee _____.
- The yelping yellow _____.